



The Secret of the Clockwork Garden

מאת irit kogan

Elara lived in a house full of echoes and dust, but her favorite place was her grandfather's library. One rainy afternoon, while searching for a book on constellations, she pulled on a heavy leather spine titled "The Heart of the Machine." To her surprise, the entire bookshelf groaned and pivoted inward, revealing a narrow stone passage lit by a faint, rhythmic golden pulse



Elara crept down the stairs, her heart hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird. At the bottom, she stepped into a world she never could have imagined. It was a massive underground greenhouse, but instead of green leaves and soft petals, everything was made of metal. Brass vines climbed the walls, and silver lilies stood tall, their petals clicking softly as they caught the artificial light



As Elara explored the metallic forest, she heard a frantic whirring sound coming from a thicket of copper brambles. She knelt and found a small, round bird made of burnished gold. Its wings were tangled in a mess of loose wires, and its tiny sapphire eyes flickered with a dim, fading light. "Don't worry," Elara whispered, "I can help



Elara reached into her pocket and pulled out the small silver wrench she always carried for her own inventions. With careful, steady hands, she began to loosen the tight coils of wire.

Sprocket stayed perfectly still, watching her with his glowing blue eyes as she worked to set him free from the metallic trap



With one final snip, the bird was free. Sprocket chirped a sequence of musical pings and took to the air. His wings moved with a soft, whirring hum, trailing a faint golden dust behind them. He circled Elara's head twice before landing on her shoulder, pointing his beak toward the center of the garden where a massive, silent tower stood.



You want me to follow you?"

Elara asked. Sprocket chirped and flew toward the tower. When they reached it, Elara saw a giant clock face at the base, but the gears weren't moving. The garden felt cold and stagnant. Elara realized that the clock was the heart of the garden, and it .had stopped beating



Suddenly, a loud, metallic screech echoed through the tower. A massive shadow stretched across the floor, and Elara froze. Something huge was moving in the rafters above, its many legs clicking against the metal beams. She gripped her wrench tightly, wondering if she had made a terrible mistake by coming here



The creature descended slowly.

It was a giant spider made of polished bronze, its eight legs tipped with delicate needle-like points. This was Spindle, the guardian of the garden. He didn't look angry, though; his many glass eyes looked dull and sad. In one of his front legs, he held a cracked crystal gear that was weeping a thick, black oil



Spindle placed the new gear into the heart of the clock. With a deafening thrum, the garden roared to life. The brass vines began to grow, the silver lilies opened wide, and the air filled with the sweet smell of ozone and warm oil. Sprocket landed on Elara's head, singing a triumphant song. The Secret Garden was finally awake, and Elara knew she had found a new .home

